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Lal Aragami's Vernacular Sufi Poetics: Spiritual Vision, Religious Plurality and Cultural Memory in Kashmiri Literature

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Abstract

Lala Aragami, popularly known as Lal (Lala) Aragami or Lala Sahib (Sahib) Aragami, is an important voice in Kashmiri Sufi poetry which has not been explored enough. Aragami is remembered as a poet of compositions that were recited at religious events and shared orally throughout the community, that is, as a poet whose work merged spiritual reflection with vernacular expression and local cultural memory. Biographical descriptions indicate that he was an extremely prolific poet, but his oeuvre has not yet been adequately textually documented and critically analyzed to allow for a thorough literary evaluation of his work. This article explores his view of poetry based on the available textual and bibliographical evidence, with special emphasis on two Kashmiri couplets that have been quoted in published sources. The verses are about Kashmiri Pandit devotional practice and about Goddess Parvati, which can be used as a basis for analysing the representation of religious plurality in the poetry of Aragami. Vernacular expression, oral transmission and cultural memory are also taken into account. It also maintains a distinction between text evidence, second source evidence and critical interpretation, and suggests that Aragami deserves a more serious consideration in Kashmiri literature. The article ends by stating that an accurate transcription, transliteration, translation, and textual annotation, supported by a critical edition of his poetry are essential for a full realization of his literary contribution.

The themes of the paper are Lal Aragami, Kashmiri literature, Sufi poetry, vernacular poetics, religious plurality, cultural memory, and oral tradition.

1. Introduction

Over a long period of time, Kashmiri literature has evolved by maintaining a balance between the spiritual experience, philosophical reflections, vernacular expression and the life of the region. It is not a narrative that can be told from printed texts alone: poetry has also passed through the oral, the musical, the devotional, and the communal. This written/oral relationship is quite significant in the study of poets of Sufi poetry where its compositions are deeply entrenched in local culture.

Lal Aragami or Lala Aargami and Lala Sahib Aargami are related to Aragam in Bandipora area. There are reports in print that he was a Kashmiri-language Sufi poet and his compositions were

sung in Sufi gatherings. In his poem Spiritual Journey, Khursheed Dar writes that his poetry is grounded in the local culture and Kashmiri idiom, and is also influenced by Persian, Arabic and Sanskrit languages. According to another source, many of his poems have not yet been published and his songs are sung at religious celebrations (Dar, “Well Known”).

The scanned collection Jaam-e-Saqi (Intikhab), which was provided for this study, is an important primary-source access point. The bibliographical record also shows that the monograph, Lala Aargami, published by Sahitya Akademi in 2002 (Sahitya Akademi), is available. Later sources refer to another set, Kuliyati Lala Aargami, published (supposedly) by the Shrine Committee in 2008 (Dar, “Spiritual Journey”; Dar, “Well Known”).

This is a discussion about the connection between Aragami's popular Sufi art and Kashmiri cultural memory. Two couplets of published accounts are of special interest: one to a Kashmiri Pandit girl concerning her practice of devotion and the other, invoking the goddess Parvati (Ambardar; Dar, ‘Well Known'). These verses serve as a concentrated point to consider the impact of his poems on religious imagery outside the limited scope of a particular community. The argument is artificial, confined to what there is to be found in the two couplets, and it does not pretend to be exhaustive since it does not purport to restate the whole of Aragami's poetic philosophy.

2. **Research Objectives**

The present research explores Aragami's contribution to Kashmiri Sufi poetry, vernacular expression and local culture, invocation for religious devotion and in two accessible couplets, the oral transmission in cultural memory. It also points out the bibliographical and textual constraints that hinder us now from a more complete evaluation of his work.

3. **Methodology and Scope**

The article uses qualitative literary-historical approach with close reading method. The main primary text source is the transmitted collection of Jaam-e-Saqi (Intikhab), which is in the form of a scanned image collection attributed to Lal Aragami. The scan is written in Kashmiri perso-arabsic language. Its title page and poetry pages make it a primary textual source; while the image quality and script allow for enough transcriptions of every poem, it is not possible to do so for every poem. Therefore, if there are any readings that are not certain, then they are not given as true quotations.

The two complete couplets mentioned below have been printed in published secondary sources, in particular, in the book “Aragam” by Upender Ambardar and in KashmirPEN by Khursheed Dar (Upender Ambardar; Khursheed Dar, “Well Known”). They have not been written as critical transcriptions of the scanned collection, but rather as textual witnesses passed on in secondary publications. The study separates the facts from the primary sources, the testimony of the

secondary sources, and the critical inferences of the author. This distinction is needed so as not to put uncertain compositions to Aragami or to give unsupported page references.

4. **Biographical and Literary Background**

According to published sources, Aragami is Lal Malik, popularly known as Lalla aargami. According to Khursheed Dar's birth certificate, he was born in Chattibanday Aragam, Bandipora on 11 March 1923 (Dar, “Spiritual Journey”; Dar, “Well Known”). The social class was low; the formal education received was also brief; the jobs were milkman, labourer and imam (Dar, “Spiritual Journey”; Dar, “Well Known”). The details place his literary activity not in a traditional institutional literary context but in a social and religious setting of the local community. Aragami started his spiritual journey with Shaban Sahib Slura and subsequently became a pupil of Ama Sahib Kawa, according to Dar (Dar, “Spiritual Journey”; Dar, “Well Known”). The details of these biographies are based on published testimony and are meant to be interpreted as such; independent documentary evidence has not been substantiated in the sources consulted.

Two publications are of special interest. According to the Sahitya Akademi catalogue, Lala Aargami is a 108-page monograph first published in 2002 by Sahitya Akademi with ISBN 81-260-1375-3 (Sahitya Akademi). In “Spiritual Journey” and “Well Known”, Khursheed Dar refers to Kuliyati Lala Aargami as a collection published by the Shrine Committee in 2008. The colophon and title pages of the latter edition must be read before definitive bibliographical data is added to the edition.

5. **Context of Vernacular Sufi Poetics**

In general, Kashmiri Sufi poetry conveys spiritual/ethical issues in Kashmiri language and familiar cultural context. The vernacular is not just a means to the translation of abstract doctrine, but also a bridge between poetic experience and ordinary discourse, devotional practice and collective memory. The use of Kashmiri idiom and the reported influence of Persian, Arabic and Sanskrit vocabulary is highlighted in Dar's account of the Aragami's spiritual journey (Dar, “Spiritual Journey”).

Aragami's literary identity is deeply rooted in the language and the performance of literature. His compositions were sung at Sufi gatherings and a large part of his poetry was unpublished, reports KashmirPEN (Dar, “Well Known”). Such evidence implies the poet also existed on the page of the printed word. It also poses methodological issues on variant readings, adaptation in performance and the conservation of oral compositions.

At the moment, the corpus is not complete enough to allow for a detailed prosodic analysis. The following statements regarding Aragami's personal metrical innovations, unique formal system, and originality of style would then be premature. What evidence there is suggests a more guarded comment on his poetry: that it was grounded in the Kashmiri vernacular and in the cultural landscape of its intended audience.

6. **Devotional Plurality and Kashmiri Pandit Context**

Perhaps the most important text evidence available is the couplet quoted by Upender Ambardar in his narration of Aragam and then again by Khursheed Dar (Ambardar 42; Dar, "Well Known"):

Mauri Kohete Kanie Kohete Kani,
Karee Pooja, Yinai Mushravak Lai.

In lines 42, the poet speaks to a Kashmiri Pandit girl and asks her to revere the stone idol as the deity with total commitment.Ambardar explains that in line 42 the poet is speaking to a Kashmiri Pandit girl and asking her to pray to the deity of the stone idol with undivided attention. The same couplet is repeated and an explanation similar to that offered by Dar (Dar, "Well Known"). These printed interpretations, based on the explanations of the Pandits, can be translated into English in an interpretative way: "O daughter of the Pandits, practise with all your heart; pray earnestly to the deity you hold dear."

The rendering is interpretative since the original Kashmiri wordings have to date not been collated against a clear and authoritative print version. Care must be taken in literal translation to watch for dialects of vocabulary, grammar and the exact meaning of words. It is important to distinguish: The translation must not be more certain than the text allows.

This couplet is unique in capturing another community's piety without mocking it. The speaker tells the addressee to go about her religious practice fully, as described in the published sources. The ethical value of it is that it presents a devotional ritual in a sympathetic way, in a context not immediately related to the speaker's current religious context. It does not develop an extensive theological framework, but it does offer a glimpse at a literary interaction with Kashmiri Pandit religious culture (Ambardar; Dar, "Well Known").

7. **God and Culture: A Way of Life**

Ambardar gives a second couplet, which is repeated as follows (42):

I went to Haran, the mother of the mountains, and took the Shiva Lingam in the name of Praran Yaeti from there.

Sonihaer Paad Yaepaar Trav Lotie Parvati Lo.

Ambardar considers these lines as an expression of reverence towards Goddess Parvati (Ambardar). The published account would set the subject of the couplet, but this alone is not enough to be confident in a word-by-word translation in English. Therefore, a literal translation is withheld until the original Kashmiri text is verified.

The invocation of Parvati is significant in the context of the study of cultural consciousness of Aragami as it introduces a Hindu religious icon into the poetic world of a Kashmiri Sufi poet. The verse, read in conjunction with the couplet directed to a Kashmiri Pandit girl, provides some indications of interaction with devotional imagery of more than one religious community. The two examples suggest that the familiarity and religious recognition of each culture is central to the interpretation of Aragami's poetry, but are not extensive enough to claim any universal significance.

8. **Poetic aesthetics & local imagery**

A careful examination of a poet's aesthetics will be able to point to diction, rhythm, figurative language, sound patterns, and form in the original poems. According to Dar, Aragami's poetry is rich in Kashmiri idiom, and has been inspired by Persian, Arabic, and Sanskrit words (Dar, "Spiritual Journey"). KashmirPEN also commends his metaphor and simile (Dar, "Well Known"). These are useful critical commentaries, but they are only secondary descriptions until they can be supported by a longer series of close readings of a larger group of poems.

It is evident from the two surviving couplets that these are not abstract or placeless spiritual phrases, but culturally situated images. Their references to Kashmiri Pandit devotional context and references to Parvati bring poetic expression to the religious and cultural milieu of Kashmir. This would be better achieved by an aesthetic analysis of the original texts focusing on patterns of address, repetition, rhyme, rhythm, metaphor, and on the relationship between the spoken and the written.

9. **Oral Performance and Textual Preservation**

Given that people reported hearing Aragami's poetry performed in Sufi gatherings, one could assume that a means of dissemination of poetry involved the preserve of memory and the performance of poetry (Dar, "Spiritual Journey"; Dar, "Well Known"). Poems can be passed down orally, even if they are not a part of popular print publications. Sings and listeners and devotees can help remember the verses with repeated singing and musical presentation.

There are also some textual issues related to oral transmission: variant wording, musical adaptation, uncertainty of authorship, and variations between the printed and performed texts. A critical edition should contain the original Kashmiri script, uniform transliteration, literal and literary translations and variants of the poems as well as mention of the source of each poem. If a composition is recorded orally, the performer and conditions of the recording should also be noted.

10. **Humanities Education and Student Learning**

However, the lack of a poet in the mainstream of academic activity doesn't mean that his poetry is not of a very high quality. Literary visibility can be subject to unequal publication and translation and to uneven preservation. The case of Aragami indicates the need for analysis of the regional and orally transmitted poetic traditions, along with those of widely anthologised poets. The Sahitya Akademi monograph and the report in 2008 of a collection of his works provide good bibliographical indications, but a comprehensive list of his works is still needed (Sahitya Akademi; Dar, "Spiritual Journey").

The literary heritage of Aragami should not be at the mercy of mere biographical sketch and devotional adoration. It demands a systematic approach to the poems, their language features, literary forms, text variations and connection with the history of the literature of Kashmir.

11. **Findings and Discussion**

Based on the available evidence, there are several findings. First, Aragami is remembered as a Kashmiri Sufi poet connected with the oral devotional circulation (Dar, “Well Known”). Secondly, two entire couplets that are mentioned in published sources refer to a devotional setting that involves Kashmiri Pandits and the invocation of Parvati provide a specific context for the investigation of religious plurality (Ambardar; Dar, “Well Known”). Third, vernacular idiom and figurative richness are indicated in published descriptions but a larger corpus is needed in order to test the generalisations of style. Fourthly, unpublished poetry is an important scholarly priority due to reports.Fourthly, the reports mean that there is a high priority for preserving text for poetry that has not been published. Lastly conflicting biographical reports illustrate a need for more reliable documentation.

12. **Conclusion**

Lal Aragami should be given a continued focus in Kashmiri literary studies. The potential pairings of couplets imply that the work was composed poetically with reference to religion and religious figures in a community that is not simply one's own, and oral transmission accounts place it in an oral vernacular tradition. These results must be taken with a grain of salt since the present study has not claimed to be a representative sampling of his work, to provide a definitive translation of both couplets, or to resolve any of the uncertainties of his biography.
An accurate transcription, transliteration, translation, textual notes and biographical documentation would be a significant contribution to literary studies in Kashmiri if a critical edition of Jaam-e-Saqi (Intikhab) and Kuliyati Lala Aargami are published. Aragami's literary contribution is not to be limited to local remembrance and to the few biographical notes. In the context of sustained scholarly engagement with his poetry one could retrieve an important vernacular voice and make it a part of a more comprehensive Kashmiri literary history.

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